

The “Column Offset” is the position of the column, counting from the left, from which the cell value is to be returned. So to return the value from the second column of the range, the Column Offset will be 2.

By default, VLOOKUP looks up an approximate value if an exact value is not found. For example, if the value being looked up is 300, in the absence of 300 the nearest value is looked up and the cell value in the offset column is returned. If only the exact value is to be returned, the default behaviour can be curtailed by specifying FALSE in the Type of Lookup Toggle field. In this case, if an exact match is not found, the “#NA” error is displayed. Since this field is optional, entering TRUE, or leaving this field empty, will result in the default behaviour.

Before VLOOKUP is used in its default mode, the cell range needs to be sorted in ascending order of the sort key column. If only exact matches are to be looked up, the sorting is not needed.

HLOOKUP is similar to VLOOKUP, the difference being that HLOOKUP looks up data in the first row of a cell range. The HLOOKUP Function has a similar syntax, with Column offset being replaced with Row Offset. (In case it isn't obvious, the V and H in VLOOKUP and HLOOKUP stand for Vertical and Horizontal respectively.)